Praise of the One Beyond Praise

Stutyatītastava · Toh 1129 · Derge Tengyur
བསྟོད་ལས་འདས་པར་བསྟོད

Praise of the One Beyond Praise, known in Sanskrit as the Stutyatītastava and in Tibetan as Töpa lé Dépar Töpa, is a short hymn in verse ascribed in its colophon to the master Nāgārjuna, in which the poet sets out to praise the Buddha even though the Buddha lies beyond all praise. Its verses marvel that one who sees all things as void of self and other still never turns his compassion away from beings, and they weave the core arguments of the Middle Way into devotion: things do not arise from conditions in which they are not present, all entities are like reflections, the characteristics of the conditioned cannot stand up to analysis, and even emptiness, taught to free beings from all views, is a mere designation that the Buddha does not hold to be real. The hymn closes by dedicating its merit so that the whole world may become supreme in true knowledge. It is Toh 1129 in the Tengyur, where it belongs to the section of praises (stotra).

In the language of India: rutastistavaṃ. In the language of Tibet: Praise of the One Beyond Praise.

Homage to the youthful Mañjuśrī.

Although the Tathāgata (the Buddha),
Who has gone by the unsurpassed path, is beyond praise,
With a mind of reverence and delight
I shall praise the one beyond praise.

Although you see entities as void
Of self, of other, and of both,
That your compassion does not turn away
From sentient beings is a wonder.

That you have taught phenomena,
Which are unborn by their essential nature
And whose domain lies beyond words:
This is your wonder.

Although you proclaimed
The aggregates, the elements, and the sense sources,
Afterward you also turned back
All clinging to them.

"Whatever is not present in the conditions,
How could such entities arise from conditions?"
By your saying this, O wise one,
Conceptual elaborations are cut off.

If things are established from a collection,
Those who see the collection as arising from causes,
You have clearly seen,
Rely upon the two extremes.

You fully accept that entities
Are established in dependence on conditions;
And you, Teacher, have seen this
To be the flaw of what is made in that way.

They come from nowhere,
And they go nowhere;
All entities, you hold,
Are like reflections.

So that all views might be abandoned,
Protector, you taught emptiness;
Yet that too is a mere designation:
Protector, you do not hold it to be real.

You do not hold to empty or not empty;
You delight in neither of the two;
And so, free of dispute about it,
You engage in great speech.

"It is not other, it is not an existent entity;
It is not other, it is not both": this too you said.
Since oneness and otherness are abandoned,
There is no entity in any way at all.

If the three, arising and the rest, existed,
There would be characteristics of the conditioned;
And for those as well, a separate triad
Of arising and the rest would follow.

The three, arising and the rest, taken separately,
Are incapable of their action with respect to the conditioned;
And when gathered together into one,

They cannot even meet.

Thus there is neither a characterized basis nor a mark;
Since in this way these are not established,
If the conditioned is not established,
How could the unconditioned be established?

When you, the lion of speakers,
Spoke in this way, the arrogance of the disputants,
Those goring elephants, was dispelled,
As if by a lion.

Just as one who has entered the path
Does not rely on the various harms and the bad paths of views,
So, relying on you, one does not rely
On existence, nor even on nonexistence.

You spoke with an underlying intent,
And those who understand it in that way
Need not understand again
What you spoke with that intent.

Whoever understands in this way
That all entities are the same as nirvāṇa,
How then, in such a one,
Could the grasping at an "I" arise?

Supreme among those with true knowledge,
Knower of reality: by whatever merit is mine
From praising you in this way,
May the world become supreme in true knowledge.

The Praise of the One Beyond Praise, composed by the revered great master, the noble Nāgārjuna, is complete.

Translator's Notes

• In the eleventh stanza the first line reads "not other" (□□□□□□□), repeating the second line; since the third line speaks of abandoning both oneness and otherness, "not one" (□□□□□□□□) may have been intended, but I have translated the text as it stands. Stanzas twelve to fourteen restate the argument of Nāgārjuna's Root Verses on the Middle Way, chapter seven, against arising, abiding, and perishing as real characteristics of the conditioned; □□ in the thirteenth stanza is the "action" or function of those characteristics. The seventeenth stanza is terse; I

take □□□□□□□□ as "again," meaning that those who grasp the intent behind the provisional teachings need not reinterpret them.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.